

Imaginal Rehearsal Handout

Imaginal rehearsal is a 4-step process recommended for preparing ourselves for action. The 4 steps can be summarized using the acronym WOOP: Imagining a **Wished-for** action, imagining the desired **Outcome** of carrying this through successfully, recognizing the **Obstacles** that may stand in your way, and coming up with a **Plan** to overcome these, which is then imagined in detailed.

You can practice imaginal rehearsal by following these steps:

1. Start by closing your eyes and imagining yourself carrying out the **Wished-for** or desired action. Try to imagine this scenario as vividly and as fully as you can. (e.g., placing a phone call that is important but which you've been procrastinating about). Where are you as you do this? Who is around you? What do your senses tell you? What resources do you need? Take at least 30 seconds to really flesh this out.
2. Next, imagine the positive **Outcome** that would follow from carrying out the action successfully. Really let yourself imagine what this feel like – that is, how your emotions and even your physiological reactions would feel if this occurs (e.g., you have one less thing to worry about; you feel less tense, that knot in your stomach is gone). Take at least 30-45 seconds to immerse yourself in these feelings.
3. Next, turn your thoughts to the **Obstacles** you may encounter when carrying out this action. This is the time to acknowledge these obstacles, which may be formidable. Do this in a really detailed way too (e.g., you may be really apprehensive about the phone call and dread it; this may lead you to postpone it; you may feel like you really need to prepare for it but don't have the time to do so; etc.). Spend at least 30 seconds, or as much as needed, acknowledging the obstacles for what they are.
4. Once the obstacles are really clear in your mind, devise a **Plan** to overcome them. What changes should you make to the plan so that you can overcome these obstacles? What help or resources would you need? How will you go about getting these resources? This is a particularly important step; devote as much time as needed, but at least 1-2 minutes, to thinking through the plan.

Once you've completed these four steps – which we recommend you do with your eyes closed, so that you could get really vivid images, you're ready to conclude things. To do that, imagine yourself carrying out the *plan* you just devised in your mind. Let it succeed in overcoming the *obstacles*, as formidable as they are. Imagine yourself completing the *wished-for* action or getting to the wished-for state, and let yourself feel the positive *outcomes* you wanted. After you've done that, you may want to write down some notes or concrete plans (e.g., a scheduled time to make that phone call).